

THE M FACTOR

POLITICS OF TOKENISM IS AT FULL PLAY IN THE VICE-PRESIDENTIAL ELECTION

Career diplomat Mohammad Hamid Ansari made his way uncomfortably through the cordon of Congress and Left heavyweights to file his nomination papers for the vice-presidential election on July 23. Ansari is set to succeed Bhairon Singh Shekhawat as the nation's 13th vice-president on August 18. The impending change is remarkable for a man who spent most of his active years in West Asia as India's ambassador. And for UPA, placing a Muslim as deputy completed the circle of tokenism that began with the installation of a woman President.

By fielding Rajya Sabha's former deputy chairperson Najma Heptullah as the NDA's candidate, BJP, too, gave in to the compulsion of minority politics. The newly-formed alliance of eight parties, called the UNPA, had already selected SP leader Rasheed Masood last week. Needless to say, competitive tokenism is the theme of the vice-presidential election.

Within a year of being appointed chairperson of the National Commission for Minorities, Ansari was pushed into the ceremonial position of vice-president by the Left Front. With a President of their choice, Congress leaders were more than happy to accept Ansari. Although his views on India's engagement with the US have been at odds with those of Sonia Gandhi and Manmohan Singh, the duo endorsed his candidature on behalf of the UPA for two reasons. First, despite doubts within the Left Front about Pratibha Patil, Left leaders had defended the Congress's choice in public. Congress had to return the favour. Second, the deliberate selection of a Muslim could

only boost the Congress's weakening pro-minority image.

At 65, Ansari, who was awarded the Padma Shri by the Congress government in 1984, is the face of the liberal modern Muslim. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat, who is said to

nuclear deal with the US appears to be in place now, and with the next general elections just two years away, Ansari's place in the chain of command is likely to be treated lightly by the Congress. Also, the Left's symbolic control over Parliament would be absolute with

Ansari presiding over the Rajya Sabha. Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee has probably now understood the CPI(M) strategy of not supporting his desire to be either President or vice-president.

Ansari is expected to fetch around 422 votes from the electoral college of 790 MPs. BJP spokesperson Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi, who denies that his party proposed Heptullah for the post only because she is Muslim, said the Shiv Sena and Trinamool Congress are yet to confirm their participation in the election. Regardless of its proximity to BJP, the Sena had voted for Patil in the presidential polls for the sake of Maharashtra, while Trinamool Congress had abstained because of BJP's reluctance to fight the Congress for Kalam's second term. Heptullah is estimated to bag close to 237 votes.

The vice-president is elected by MPs through single transferable votes, and unlike the presidential poll, the election is less complicated as MLAs do not vote. BJP had earlier contemplated putting up Deputy Lok Sabha Speaker C.S. Atwal for the post, but ally Akali Dal had rejected the bid. The numbers game hints to a victory for the UPA. Ansari will be the third Muslim in the chair after Zakir Hussain (1962-1967) and Mohammed Hidayatullah (1979-1984).

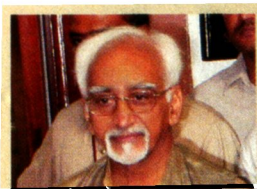
Desperate for a third alternative identity, the UNPA is banking on Masood who is expected to get not more than 81 votes. SP maintains that picking a Muslim was coincidental. "I will not win but the fight is important," Masood says. Everyone loves a Muslim vice-president.

by Satarupa Bhattacharjya

ELECTORAL COLLEGE

790 MPs FROM BOTH HOUSES OF PARLIAMENT

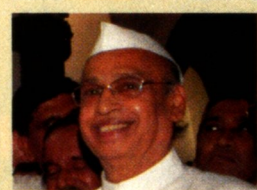
Estimated votes



**MOHAMMAD
HAMID ANSARI**
(UPA-Left)
422



**NAJMA
HEPTULLAH**
(NDA)
237



**RASHEED
MASOOD (UNPA)**
81

** The remaining, unaccounted votes belong to Independents in both Houses and nominated members of the Rajya Sabha. Trinamool Congress and Shiv Sena are yet to decide on who to vote for or whether to abstain.

have hammered out the proposal after looking up several other Left-leaning individuals from the academia and the arts, described Ansari as a person with an "exemplary record in his field". Ansari's expertise, which easily stretches from West-Asian politics to oil diplomacy, might inconvenience the Congress once in a while. But since the

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